

Double Pendulum and The Chaos Theory

AP Calculus EOC Project

Winston (Wenqin) Huang

Olive Tree International Academy

May-June, 2026

Related CALCAB Knowledge

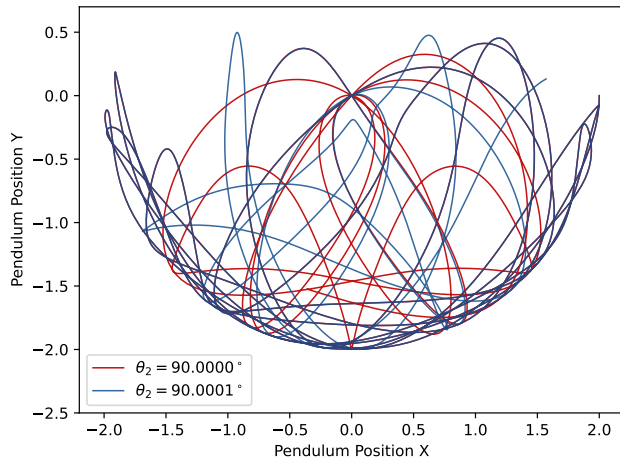
Differential Equation: It is the core of simulation algorithm we applied in this project, the entire simulation was run based on a differential equation derived by *Lagrangian Mechanics*, so the differential equation we learned in unit 7 is the core of our project.

Limit and Approaching: In our project, the observation of the simulation accuracy as time step changes is also a core part. By speculating the result approaches a value as step decreases (becomes more accurate), we could choose a suitable time step for simulation that is both efficient and accurate.

Integration (by Part): For deriving Euler-Lagrange Equation.

Introduction To The Chaos Theory

Two Slightly Different Pendula Simulation Outcome



Uncertain Outcome: In a chaotic system described in the Chaos Theory, even a *negligible* disturbance or initial differences could cause an incredibly different result.

Determinable, though Chaotic: Chaotic doesn't mean random and indeterminate, instead, chaotic systems could be predicted by calculations and modeling if one has incredibly precise data, though the result is input-sensitive.

Introduction To DE Calculation Approaches

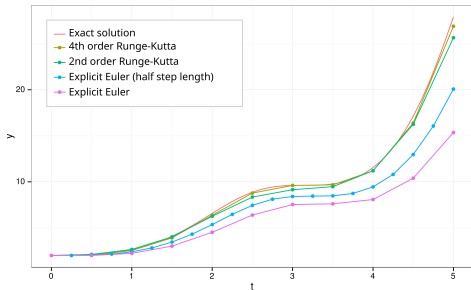


Figure: Comparison of the Runge-Kutta methods for the differential equation. Red line is the exact solution, 4th order Runge-Kutta is what we mainly use in this project, and is significantly more accurate. Figure from Wikimedia Commons, CC BY-SA 3.0 

Fourth-Order Runge-Kutta (RK4) Approach:

$$\text{Let } \frac{dy}{dx} = f(x, y),$$

$$y_{n+1} = y_n + \frac{\Delta x}{6}(k_1 + 2k_2 + 2k_3 + k_4)$$

Where,

$$k_1 = f(x_n, y_n)$$

$$k_2 = f\left(x_n + \frac{\Delta x}{2}, y_n + \frac{\Delta x}{2}k_1\right)$$

$$k_3 = f\left(x_n + \frac{\Delta x}{2}, y_n + \frac{\Delta x}{2}k_2\right)$$

$$k_4 = f(x_n + \Delta x, y_n + \Delta x k_3)$$

Euler's Method: Simple DE Approximation

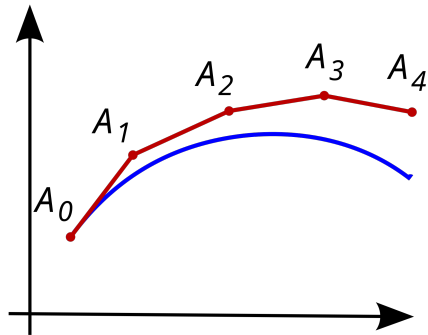


Figure: Illustration of the Euler method. The unknown curve is in blue, and its Euler approximation is in red. Figure from Wikimedia Commons, Public Domain. 

Euler's Method:

$$\text{Let } \frac{dy}{dx} = f(x, y),$$

$$y_{n+1} = y_n + \Delta x f(x_n, y_n)$$

The key of Euler's Method is to use the slope at f_n as the approximation slope of the entire step (Δx), it's quite like a common sense lol. So Euler's Method underestimates when the actual function concaves up and overestimates when the function concaves down.

Double Pendulum, Where Newtonian Physics Dies

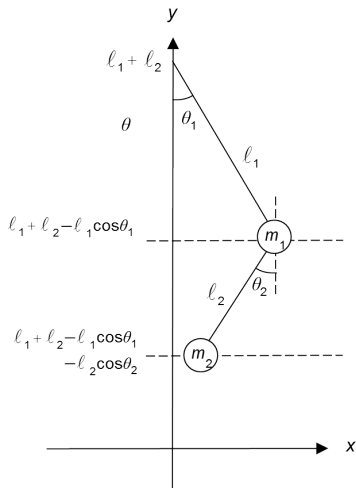


Figure from Wikimedia Commons account
 $\mathbf{F} = q(\mathbf{E} + \mathbf{v} \times \mathbf{B})$, CC BY-SA 3.0

- Newtonian Physics is based on calculation of forces, and the motion of objects is determined by classic formula $F = ma$.
- But in this problem, each variable are *interdependent* and *non-linear*, which makes this problem extremely complex (as complicated as three body problem) using Newtonian Physics to analyze.
- An approach physicists come up with is *Lagrangian Mechanics*, basically using Energy analysis to evaluate, and construct the system of differential equations.

Lagrangian Physics and Double Pendulum

Start from the Euler-Lagrangian Equation,

$$\frac{\partial L}{\partial q} - \frac{d}{dt} \frac{\partial L}{\partial \dot{q}} = 0 \quad (1)$$

where the Lagrangian $L = T - V$, ∂ (in multivariable calculus) basically means what d represents in normal calculus, q is the generalized coordinates, which is angle (θ_i) in our problem.

Citing 1, for double pendulums, we have

$$\frac{d}{dt} \left(\frac{\partial L}{\partial \dot{\theta}_1} \right) - \frac{\partial L}{\partial \theta_1} = 0, \quad \frac{d}{dt} \left(\frac{\partial L}{\partial \dot{\theta}_2} \right) - \frac{\partial L}{\partial \theta_2} = 0 \quad (2)$$

Lagrangian Physics and Double Pendulum

Now let's move on to physics, deriving expressions for energy.

Position of Ball 1: $x_1 = l_1 \sin \theta_1$, $y_1 = -l_1 \cos \theta_1$

Position of Ball 2: $x_2 = x_1 + l_2 \sin \theta_2$, $y_2 = y_1 - l_2 \cos \theta_2$

So,

Speed of Ball 1 $v_1 = \frac{dx_1}{dt}$, Speed of Ball 2 $v_2 = \frac{dx_2}{dt}$

Total $E_k = \frac{1}{2}m_1(v_1)^2 + \frac{1}{2}m_2(v_2)^2$, Total $E_p = m_1gy_1 + m_2gy_2$

$$L = T - V = E_k - E_p = \frac{1}{2}m_1(v_1)^2 + \frac{1}{2}m_2(v_2)^2 - m_1gy_1 - m_2gy_2$$

Double Pendulum Equation System Derivation

Substitute this Lagrangian L expression back into formula (2) mentioned before,

For example, for $\frac{\partial L}{\partial \theta_1}$, the partial differentiation could be calculated as:

$$\begin{aligned}\frac{\partial L}{\partial \theta_1} = \frac{\partial}{\partial \theta_1} & \left[\frac{1}{2} m_1 (l_1^2 \cos^2 \theta_1 \cdot \dot{\theta}_1^2 + l_1^2 \sin^2 \theta_1 \cdot \dot{\theta}_1^2) \right. \\ & + \frac{1}{2} m_2 (A + B) \\ & \left. - m_1 g (-l_1 \cos \theta_1) - m_2 g (-l_1 \cos \theta_1 - l_2 \cos \theta_2) \right] \\ A = & l_1^2 \cos^2 \theta_1 \cdot \dot{\theta}_1^2 + l_2^2 \cos^2 \theta_2 \cdot \dot{\theta}_2^2 + 2 l_1 l_2 \cos \theta_1 \cos \theta_2 \cdot \dot{\theta}_1 \dot{\theta}_2, \\ B = & l_1^2 \sin^2 \theta_1 \cdot \dot{\theta}_1^2 + l_2^2 \sin^2 \theta_2 \cdot \dot{\theta}_2^2 + 2 l_1 l_2 \sin \theta_1 \sin \theta_2 \cdot \dot{\theta}_1 \dot{\theta}_2\end{aligned}$$

After repeating this procedure 4 times, the equation could be expanded and solved.

Methodology and Experiment

The system of differential equations we use in this project can be written as:
(*The derivation process is available in the appendix*).

$$\alpha_1 = \frac{d\omega_1}{dt} = \frac{-g(2m_1 + m_2) \sin(\theta_1) - m_2 g \sin(\theta_1 - 2\theta_2) - 2 \sin(\Delta) m_2 (\omega_2^2 l_2 + \omega_1^2 l_1 \cos(\Delta))}{l_1 \cdot [2m_1 + m_2 - m_2 \cos(2\theta_1 - 2\theta_2)]}$$
$$\alpha_2 = \frac{d\omega_2}{dt} = \frac{2 \sin(\Delta) [\omega_1^2 l_1 (m_1 + m_2) + g(m_1 + m_2) \cos \theta_1 + \omega_2^2 l_2 m_2 \cos \Delta]}{l_2 \cdot [2m_1 + m_2 - m_2 \cos(2\theta_1 - 2\theta_2)]}$$

Where,

$$\omega_1 = \frac{d\theta_1}{dt}, \omega_2 = \frac{d\theta_2}{dt}, \Delta = \theta_1 - \theta_2$$

In this system, $\theta_{\bullet}$, $\omega_{\bullet}$, and $\alpha_{\bullet}$ respectively represents angular position, angular speed and angular acceleration for each part of the pendulum. $m_{\bullet}$ is the symbol of the mass of each pendulum, and $l_{\bullet}$ is the length of each pendulum.

Methodology and Experiment

- ▶ **Experiment 1:** Simulating double pendulum motions with slight initial difference, observing and discovering the *chaos* in such systems. Visualize experimental results, and describe.
- ▶ **Experiment 2:** Observing the approach of simulation results under different time step (Δt), and evaluate the efficiency of simulation under different accuracies.
- ▶ **Experiment 3:** Evaluating the pattern of the change of chaoticness of the system under different initial conditions.